that ‘some of them want to have refrigerators, transistors, fans and the like’. ‘Let them have these,’ Vajpayee famously argued, ‘but let us impose a heavy consumer tax on these luxuries.’[62]

Similarly, the Jan Sangh called for a basic minimum income for citizens as well as a cap on their private incomes and the size of their houses. It recommended that residential plots in urban areas should not be more than 100 square yards. It was against ‘palatial buildings adorned with spacious gardens and swimming pools etc’ which it saw as ‘nothing but a vulgar display of wealth’.[63] It wanted incomes to be capped to ‘a maximum of Rs 2000 p.m. and a minimum of Rs 100 p.m. with efforts to raise the minimum so that in the foreseeable future the highest and the lowest incomes may bear a ratio of 10:1’[64] The focal point of all its policies, as Vajpayee summed it up, was ‘the *Daridra* (the poor) in whom it has seen the manifestation of *Narayana* (divinity). Making him happy and contented was for the Jana Sangh the highest form of worship.’[65]

The Post-1992 Phase: When the BJP Put ‘Economics Before Mythology’

Before 1991, the BJP was known as a party of shopkeepers and supported decentralisation of the economy for small-scale businesses. Yet, the biggest challenge to its positioning emerged with the economic reforms of 1992, unveiled by the Congress’s Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh. Through the 1980s, the BJP had largely carried forward the Jan Sangh’s ideas of a swadeshi-focused economic vision centred on ‘Gandhian Socialism’, but it started growing politically after it refocused on identity politics rather than these concerns. It spelt out its first economic policy in 1986, but as the journalist R. Vijayaraghavan wrote in a perceptive analysis, the party ‘had always been consumed with political and quasi-religious concerns’ and took relatively ‘little note of major economic policy issues’.[66]

One reason for this was that, until this point, the party had not been a serious contender for power. But things changed after 1989, when it won eighty-five of 529 seats in Parliament, and then 1991,